The Sādhana of the Solitary Hero, the Sixteen-Armed Glorious Heruka

Ekavīraśrīherukaṣoḍaśabhujasādhana · Toh 1283 · Derge Tengyur
དཔའ་བ་གཅིག་པ་དཔལ་ཧེ་རུ་ཀ་ཕྱག་བཅུ་དྲུག་པའི་སྒྲུབ་ཐབས

The Sādhana of the Solitary Hero, the Sixteen-Armed Glorious Heruka, known in Sanskrit as the Ekavīra Śrī Heruka Ṣoḍaśabhuja Sādhana and in Tibetan as Dpa' bo gcig pa dpal he ru ka phyag bcu drug pa'i sgrub pa'i thabs, is a concise manual of tantric meditation practice centered on Heruka in his solitary form, with eight faces, twenty-four eyes and sixteen arms, as he appears in the Hevajra tradition. It leads the practitioner through the preliminaries of protecting the site, making offerings to eight goddesses, confession, rejoicing, dedication, refuge and the generation of the awakened mind, then through meditation on emptiness, the visualization and empowerment of the deity in the generation stage, and on to the completion stage practices of inner fire and the innate, together with mantra recitation, the torma offering and the concluding dissolution. It is Toh 1283 in the Tengyur, where it is found among the tantra commentaries, belonging to the large class of sādhanas, or practice texts, composed in India to put the teachings of the highest yoga tantras into practice.

In Sanskrit: ekabīrasthāterukakhoḍaśabyujasādharmānāma. In Tibetan: The Sādhana of the Solitary Hero, the Sixteen-Armed Glorious Heruka.

Homage to glorious Vajrasattva.

First, one who possesses the common and the special characteristics should enter a suitable place free of obstructors, harm and the like. The sequence of activities is as follows. Lay out the maṇḍala, the painted scroll and so forth, and arrange the offerings. Having first bathed, imagine oneself as the deity, sit on a comfortable seat, and bless the five offerings with oṃ bajra puṣpe oṃ āḥ hūṃ and the like; the other offerings too are blessed with oṃ āḥ hūṃ.

Then imagine at one's own heart a hūṃ upon a sun that has arisen from the transformation of raṃ. Its light rays strike the house in which one dwells, and one imagines it filled with vajras. Guard the place with oṃ he bajra adhitiṣṭha stata na rakṣa hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ svāhā. In the same way, apply it also to guarding oneself, one's life and one's yoga, with the words oṃ ātma jiba yoga.

Then light rays radiate from the seed syllable at the heart and invite the maṇḍala of the accumulation of merit, which one visualizes clearly, as though

directly present. Then:

These excellent flowers, divine substances
born from water and from the plains,
I offer with the highest devotion:
please accept them as you wish.

oṃ bajra puṣpe jamegha samudra spharaṇa samaye hūṃ

Having made the common offerings with this and the like, again emanate eight goddesses from the seed syllable at one's own heart and make offerings. They are as follows:

Gaurī holds the moon,
Caurī the sun.
Vetālī holds flowing water,
Ghasmarī holds what gives strength.
Pukkasī holds a sandalwood tree,
Śavarī holds honey.
Caṇḍālī sounds the hand drum,
and Ḍombī embraces the neck.
They are said to act just as a man would.

Then make confession:

Whatever evil I have committed,
and whatever I have rejoiced in,
in the presence of the perfect buddhas
I confess it all, each and every one, without exception.

Then rejoice:

The merit of the buddhas and bodhisattvas,
of the noble śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas,
and of ordinary beings:
in all of it I rejoice.

Then dedicate:

All this virtue of mine
I shall bring, in common with all sentient beings,
to full ripening and completion
as unsurpassed, perfect awakening.

Then go for refuge:

To the perfect Buddha, supreme among two-legged beings,
to the sacred Dharma that he taught,
and to the Saṅgha of bodhisattvas
I go for refuge until awakening.

Then generate the aspiring mind of supreme awakening:

Once I have become perfectly
and fully awakened in unsurpassed awakening,
for the welfare and benefit of all sentient beings
I shall establish them in nonabiding nirvāṇa.

Then generate the engaged mind of supreme awakening:

Perfecting all the perfections,
generosity and the rest,
I shall rightly follow the path
of the unsurpassed Vajra Vehicle.

Then, with the light rays arising from the hūṃ mentioned before, summon all migrating sentient beings and visualize them clearly as friends and kin. One should meditate on the four immeasurables: in the aspect of loving tenderness; wishing them to be free of suffering; joy because they have obtained the means; and equanimity that enters nonconceptuality.

After that, by reciting these mantras one should meditate on emptiness. With oṃ svabhāva biśuddhaḥ dharmāte svabhāva śuddho'haṃ one establishes: "Because all phenomena are completely pure, I too am completely pure by nature." Then with oṃ śūnyatājñāna bajra svabhāva ātmako'haṃ one should abide in this: "I, that is, my very self, am the nature of the vajra of the wisdom of emptiness."

Then, in a mere instant,
imagine oneself as the deity endowed with wisdom.
In front of that, in the sky, upon a sun
transformed from the repha, from hūṃ
imagine a crossed vajra endowed with the five wisdoms.
Light radiating from the hūṃ at its hub
burns up the obstructors; imagine the fence and the tent as well.
Above that, upon a lotus and a sun,
one's own mind itself in the form of wisdom,
the hūṃ, completely transforms,

and from it comes a five-pronged vajra with the syllable hūṃ at its hub.
Or else, with its light rays, the sentient beings
of the three realms are purified, and the light rays are drawn back.
After that, from the complete transformation of the vajra,
arises glorious Heruka, with the light of the moon and of water crystal,
with eight faces, magnificent with twenty-four eyes,
with sixteen arms, his four legs trampling the four māras:
merely one's own appearance, imagined, not real.
His fangs are slightly bared, he has matted locks,
a crown of skulls and a garland of skulls,
and bears the wheel at the crown of the head and the other seals.
Imagine him dancing, legs extended and bent, in the half cross-legged posture.

Then, at one's own heart, upon a sun,
is the form of hūṃ together with a drop of nectar.
Through the union of life wind and exertion, light rays radiate.

oṃ debapicu bajra hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ svāhā

Recite this as much as one is able. After that, in order to ripen it:

Glorious Heruka of the result, become like ripened fruit,
with hand emblems, faces and the rest
as before, his color like ground eye salve.
After that, in order to complete it,
from the seed syllable on the sun at one's own heart,
the vajra, together with the seed, completely transforms
into the wisdom being, resembling oneself; at its heart
imagine the samādhi being, the sign and the seed syllable.
With its light, gather in the lords of wisdom,
and saying jaḥ hūṃ baṃ hoḥ, dissolve them into oneself:
one is then nothing other than a perfect buddha.
To make this stable, bless the six sense bases
and body, speech and mind, and confer empowerment;
one may also recite the empowerment mantras.
Having made offerings, also offer praise and taste the nectar.
The mantras to be recited for these are these:

oṃ sarbatathāgatapūja bajra svabhāva ātmako'haṃ
oṃ sarbatathāgataprastute bajra svabhāva ātmako'haṃ
oṃ sarbatathāgata amṛtasvadana bajra svabhāva ātmako'haṃ

Now, entering the completion stage:
kindle caṇḍālī, the sovereign of what can be known.
Again, by joining life wind and exertion,
by kindling the wind and fire of wisdom,
the drop of nectar descends from haṃ.
Resting and breathing out, they become inseparable.
Make the mind stable on that, one-pointedly.
As for the form of the great principal experience:
meditate on the innate, free of the characteristics
of the joys, the moments and the three families.
The sign that the mind is stable
is that it is free of subject and object, and is wisdom itself.
Its indications are like a mirage, smoke,
a lamp, and a cloudless sky.
One will surely perceive the nature of reality directly.
Meditate in this way as much as one is able,
and when weary, recite the mantra.

Oneself, the two stages gathered into one:
Heruka, the fruit of the generation stage,
is imagined like ground eye salve in color,
with hand emblems, faces and the rest as before.
In the completion stage, not conceptualizing bliss,
recite while imagining it as beyond reference.
With meditative concentration like the moon,
in a form like the moon in water,
the recitation, like an echo, is this:

oṃ aṣṭānanāya piṅgalordhvakeśavartmane caturbiṃśatinetrāya śoḍaśabhujāya kṛṣṇajīmūtabapuśe kapālamālānekādhāriṇe adhmatakrūracittāya brdhantudaṃṣṭrīṇe māraya māraya kāraya kāraya grjaya grjaya tarjaya tarjaya śoṣaya śoṣaya saptasāgarān bandha bandha nāgāṣṭakān gṛhṇa gṛhṇa śatrūṃnaṃ ha hā hi hī hu hū he hai ho hau haṃ haḥ hūṃ phaṭ svāhā

Having recited these,
offer the torma to all the bhūtas,
or, if it is midnight, perform the gaṇacakra.
Then, having made brief offerings,
with oṃ āḥ hūṃ muḥyis
request the lords of wisdom to depart,
and gather the samaya beings into one's own heart.
In one's conduct, with heightened conviction,
hold the divine pride of the generation stage,
and regard it as not two with the completion stage.
Whoever desires the path of liberation
should enter the unsurpassed, supreme vehicle,
and, relying on the instructions of the holy guru,
accomplish the Great Seal in this very life.
In this way, this has come down to me in succession;
following it, one should practice in just this way.
By whatever virtue has been gained,
may all swiftly bring it to manifestation with confidence.

The Sādhana of the Solitary Hero, the Sixteen-Armed Glorious Heruka is complete.

Translator's Notes

• The eight offering goddesses follow the Hevajra set. □□□□□□□ is not the usual Tibetan rendering of Pukkasī, but her place in the sequence and the sandalwood tree she holds point to Pukkasī; this identification is inferred. Ghasmarī is said to hold □□□□□, literally "strength," perhaps a strengthening elixir or medicine; the sense is uncertain. The line "they are said to act just as a man would" is literal and its exact point is unclear. "Repha" renders □□□□, the Sanskrit name of the letter r, here the seed (raṃ) from which the sun disk arises. Life wind and exertion render □□□□ and □□□□ (prāṇa and āyāma), the breath practices of the completion stage.
• □□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□, "a little, briefly," which the context requires. The Great Seal renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□ (mahāmudrā), the supreme attainment. The meaning of the final wish, literally "may all swiftly make conviction manifest," is somewhat uncertain.

Colophon

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Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.